Firewall Policy Complexity: From Simple ACLs to Least Privilege Network Access

BACSE203 Computer Networks · Fall 2026 · Case Study (Topic 17)

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PERMIT DENY

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Agenda

1	Part A	**Review paper**	Problem, five literature themes, research gaps
2	Part B	**Design**	Requirements, network, three policies, test method
3	Part B	**Results**	Stage-by-stage evidence, metrics, key findings
4	Part C	**Alignment**	Comparison with the literature, limitations, future work

The problem we studied

Broad rules are easy, but open

Most small networks let every department reach every server. One router ACL can close those paths.

Strict rules are safe, but costly

Each step towards least privilege adds rules, conditions and dependence on rule order, which the literature links to configuration errors.

Research question

How does refining network access policy from broad, to department-level, to service-level least privilege change (a) the unnecessary flows the policy allows and (b) the policy's size, specificity and dependence on rule order, and how do these results compare with the literature?

SECURITY COST measured together, on one network

Objectives

1

Build

A multi-department network in Packet Tracer; confirm every test flow works with no ACLs

2

Specify

Write the required and forbidden flows before writing any rule

3

Implement

Three policy stages at the same seven enforcement points

4

Measure

Unnecessary access left, and policy size, specificity and rule-order dependence

5

Stress

Design two typical policy mistakes (shadowed rule, missing DNS rule)

6

Compare

Relate the results to the literature reviewed in Part A

What the literature says (Part A)

1 Perimeter filtering

Default deny at the boundary; inside often trusted

[3], [6], [7]

2 Policy anomalies

First-match order causes shadowing and redundancy

[9]–[12]

3 Growth & misconfiguration

Real rule sets are often wrong; complexity tracks risk

[1], [2], [13]

4 Least privilege & Zero Trust

No trust from location; segment to limit lateral movement

[4], [5], [14]–[16]

5 Management tools

Detect or prevent anomalies; usability rarely tested

[10]–[13], [17]

Gaps we found, and our response

1. Empirical data on misconfiguration are dated and from few sources
2. Unnecessary access is rarely measured against written requirements
3. Security gain and management cost are seldom measured on the same policy
4. Management tools are seldom evaluated with real users

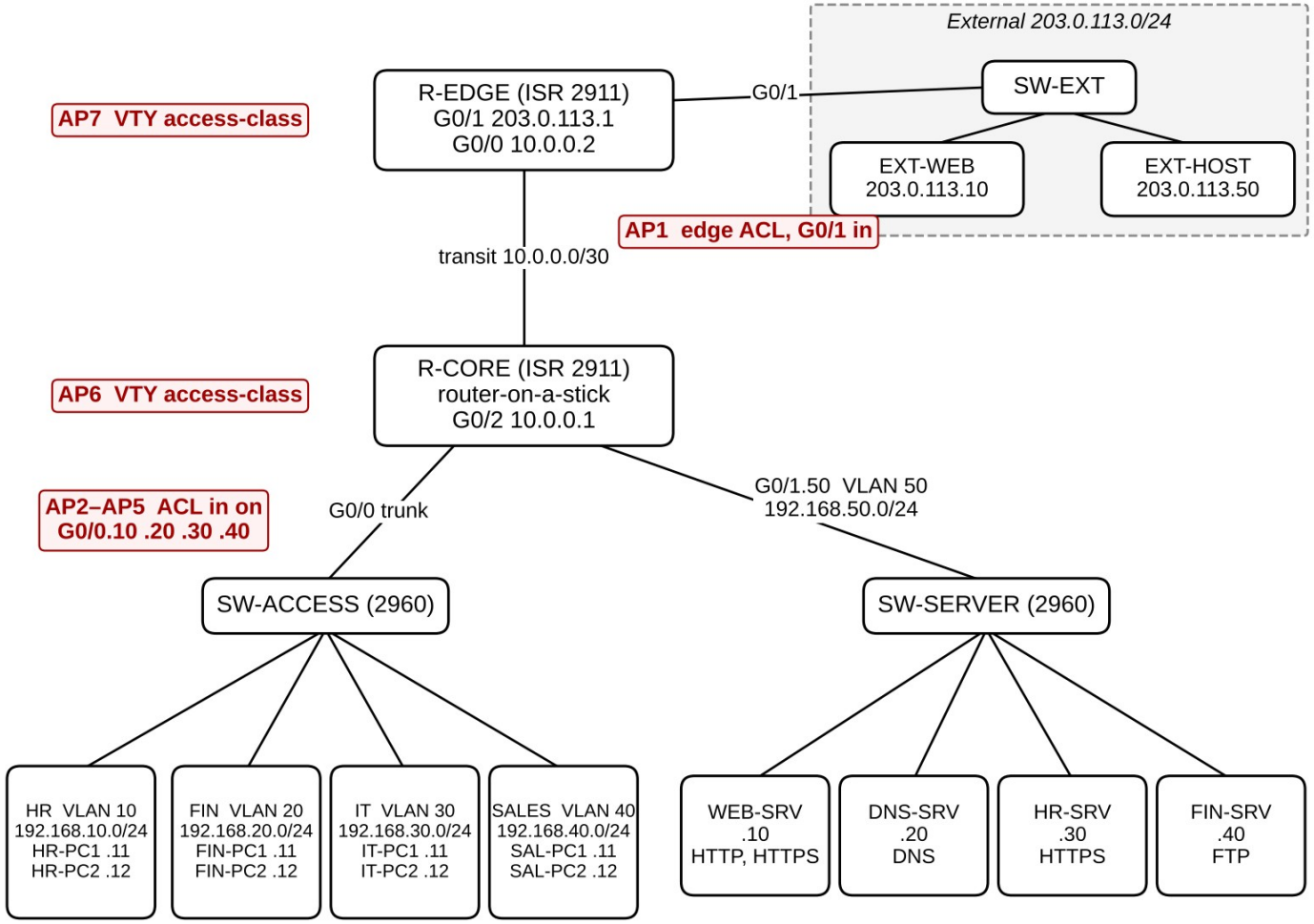
Our response to gap 3

Write required and forbidden flows first.

Apply three policies of increasing precision to one network.

Measure leakage and policy size at every stage.

Network design: 19 devices, 7 enforcement points



4 departments

HR, Finance, IT, Sales: VLANs 10–40

4 servers

Web, DNS, HR records (HTTPS), Finance (FTP)

Simulated Internet

203.0.113.0/24 (RFC 5737)

7 enforcement points

Edge ACL, 4 department ACLs, 2 router logins

Requirements written before any rule

REQUIRED

R1	All departments → DNS server (UDP 53)
R2	All departments → web portal (HTTP/HTTPS)
R3	HR → HR records server (HTTPS)
R4	Finance → finance server (FTP)
R5	IT → both routers (SSH)
R6	IT → servers (ping)
R7	All departments → Internet web
R8	Internet → public web portal

FORBIDDEN

X1	Department → other department
X2	Non-HR → HR records server
X3	Non-Finance → finance server
X4	Non-IT → router management
X5	Anyone → routers by Telnet
X6	Non-IT → servers by ping / unused ports
X7	Internet → anything except the portal

U1: PC-to-PC traffic inside one VLAN cannot be filtered by a router ACL.
"Unnecessary access" = any X flow the policy still allows.

Three policies of increasing precision

Stage 1

Broad

Any internal source → any destination; only the Internet edge filtered

10 rules

Stage 2

Department-level

Own department → whole server zone and Internet; other departments denied

25 rules

Stage 3

Least privilege

Each department → exact host, protocol and port it needs; SSH only for IT

40 rules

Stage 0 (no ACLs) is the positive control: every test must work before any rule is applied.

What a least-privilege ACL looks like

```
ip access-list extended ACL-HR-IN
 permit udp HR host DNS-SRV eq domain          R1
 permit tcp HR host WEB-SRV eq www             R2
 permit tcp HR host WEB-SRV eq 443             R2
 permit tcp HR host HR-SRV eq 443              R3
 deny   ip  HR 192.168.0.0/16                  X1–X6
 permit tcp HR any eq www                      R7
 permit tcp HR any eq 443                      R7
 deny   ip  any any
```

Host + protocol + port

Each permit names exactly what one requirement needs

Order matters

The internal deny must stay above the Internet permits, or HR can reach any internal host on 80/443

24 such pairs

In Stage 3, 24 rule pairs would change behaviour if swapped

Test method

1

Write flows

8 required, 7 forbidden, 1 uncontrollable

2

Build Stage 0

All 17 tests must work

3

Apply stage

Paste ACLs on both routers

4

Run same 17 tests

Same PCs, same order

5

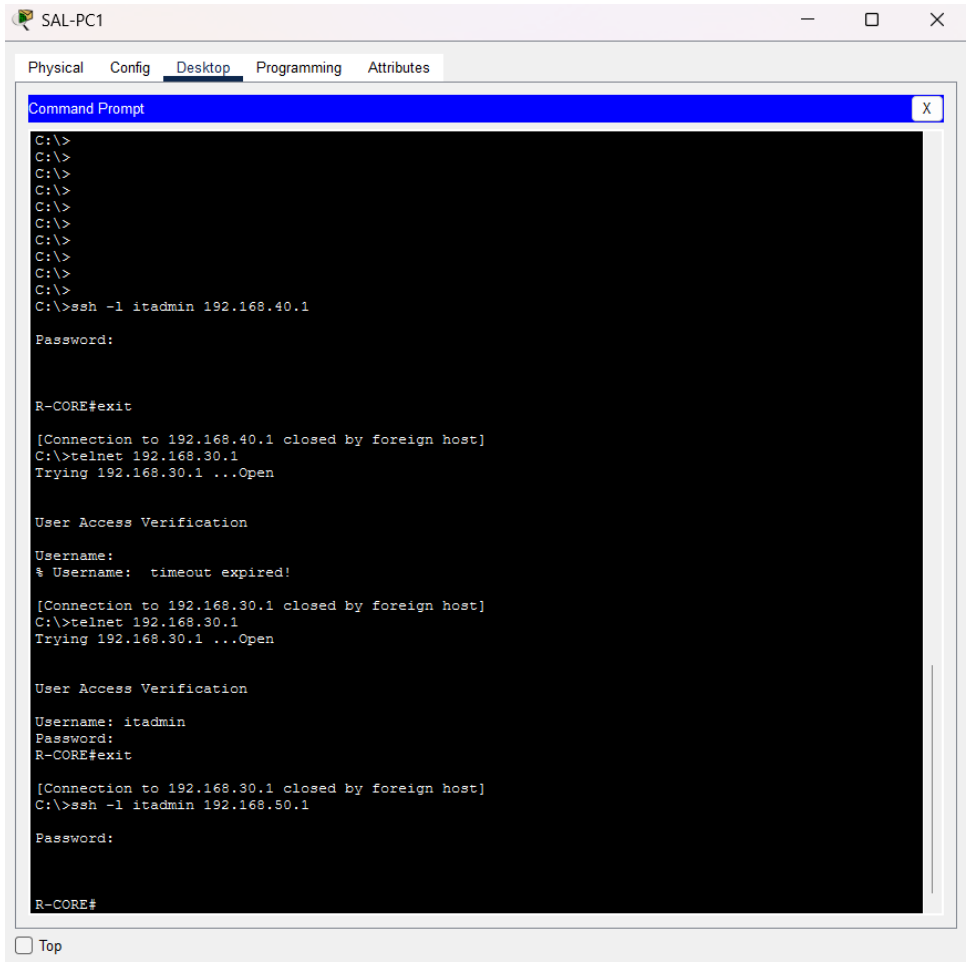
Record evidence

Screenshots and ACL counters

Metrics fixed before any result

- Leakage = forbidden tests that succeeded ÷ forbidden tests evidenced
- Required success = required tests that succeeded ÷ required tests evidenced
- Policy size, rule specificity and order-dependent rule pairs, from the configurations

Stage 0: the network works with no rules



Positive control: 17 of 17 reachable

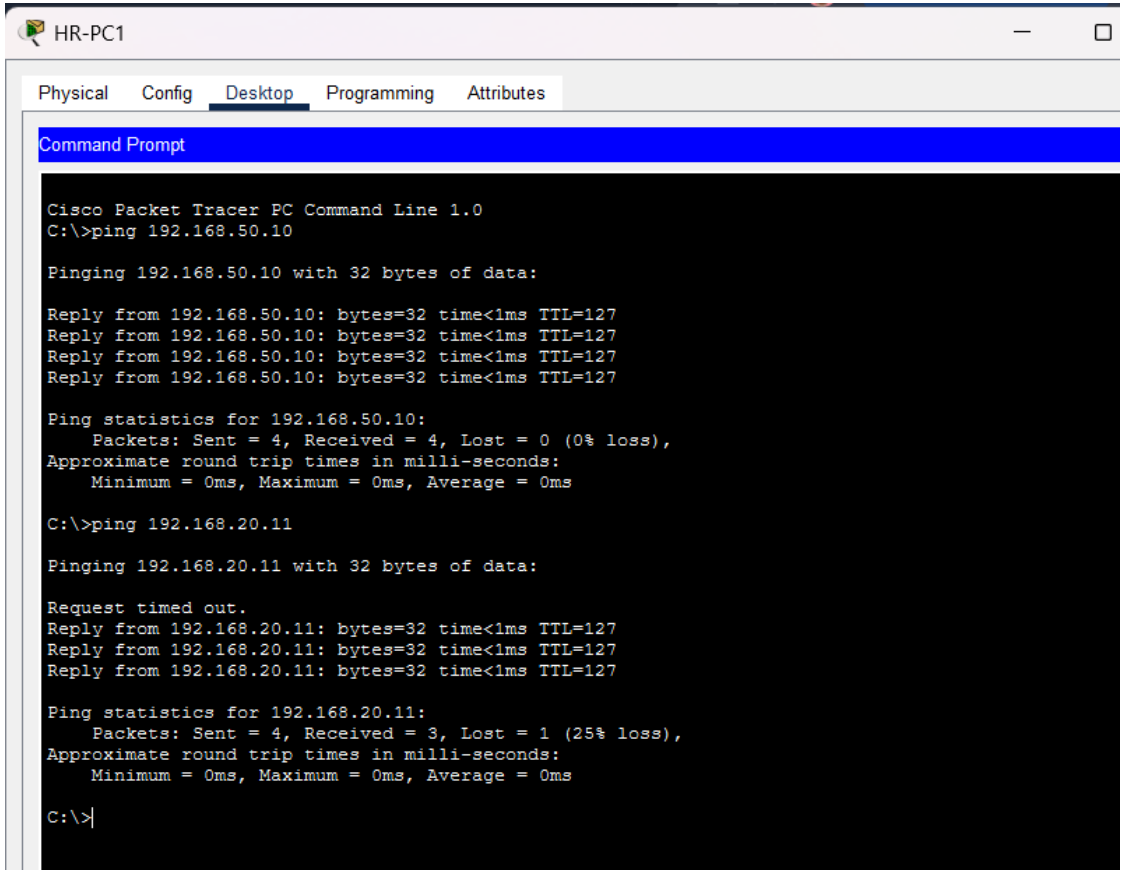
Every test, even the forbidden ones, worked with no ACLs. So any later block is caused by the policy, not by a broken cable or a stopped service.

Faults found and fixed during the build

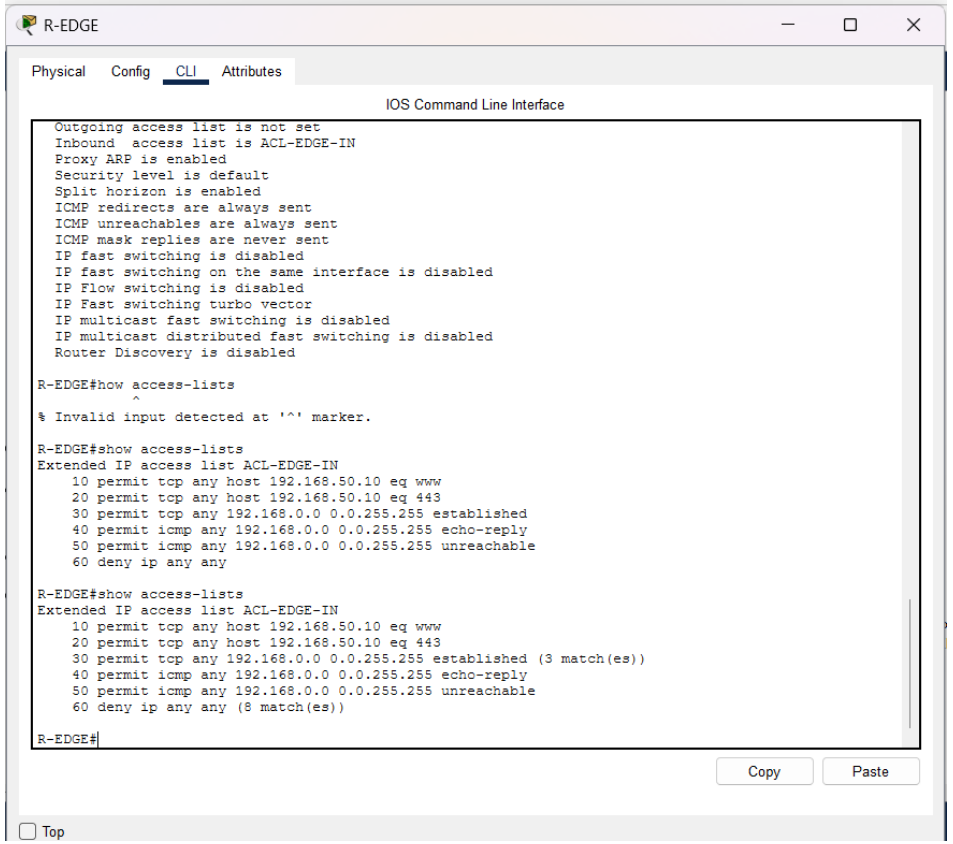
- R-CORE G0/1 had R-EDGE's address 203.0.113.1, which blocked external traffic
- DNS-SRV and EXT-WEB first had wrong IP addresses
- Two tests ran from a different PC than planned (T05, T12)

Stage 1 (broad): the inside stays open

PERMIT HR pings a server (T13) and a Finance PC (T07): both forbidden, both work

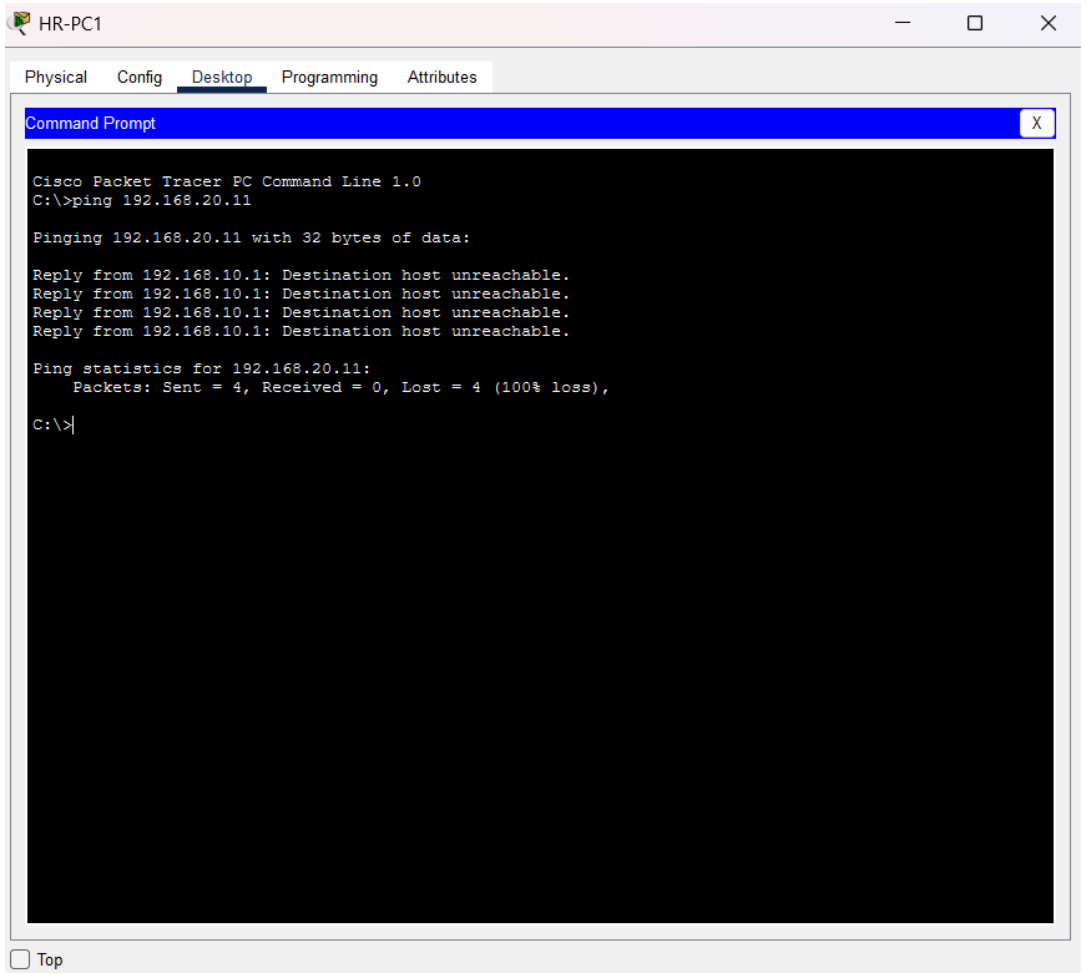


COUNTERS Edge ACL: return traffic matched 3×, deny matched 8×

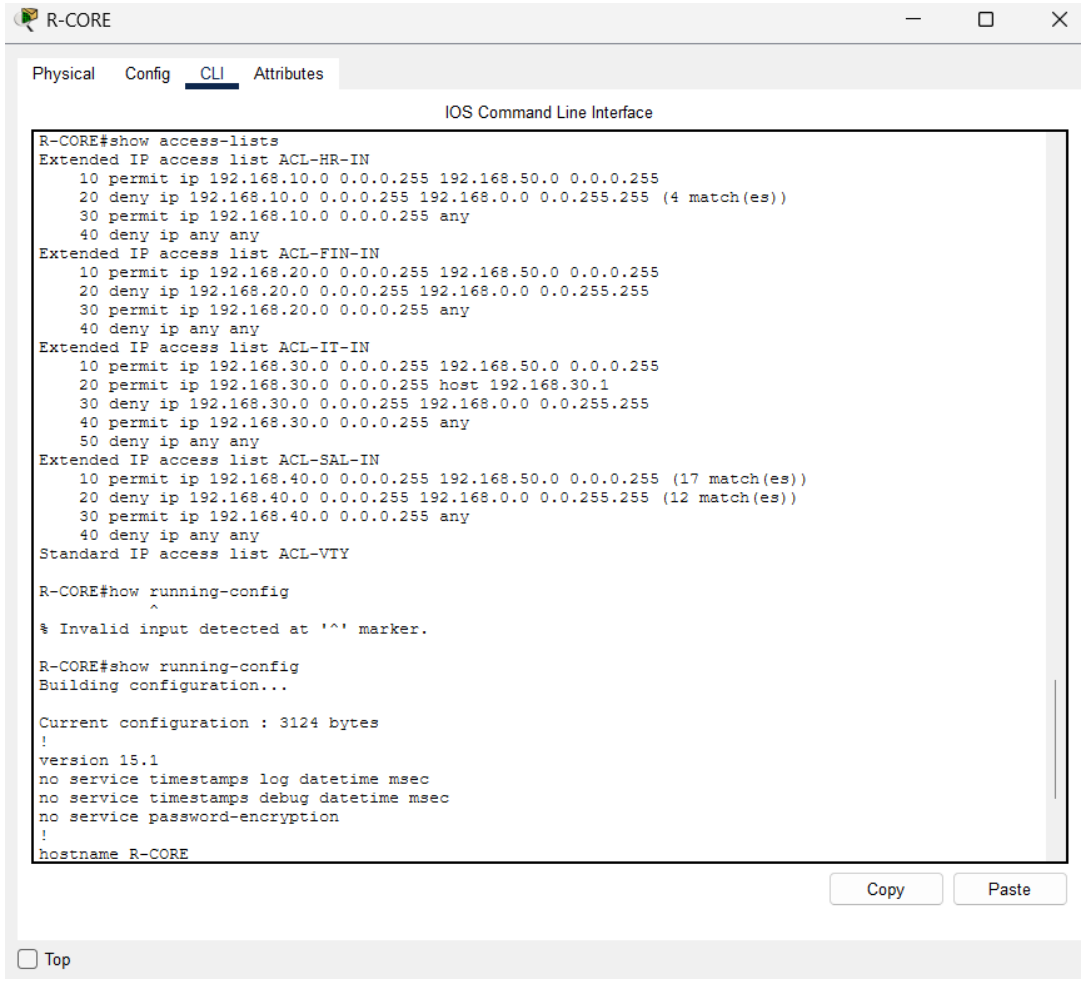


Stage 2 (department-level): departments separated

DENY HR → Finance PC now blocked (T07)



COUNTERS One ACL per department; deny entries count hits



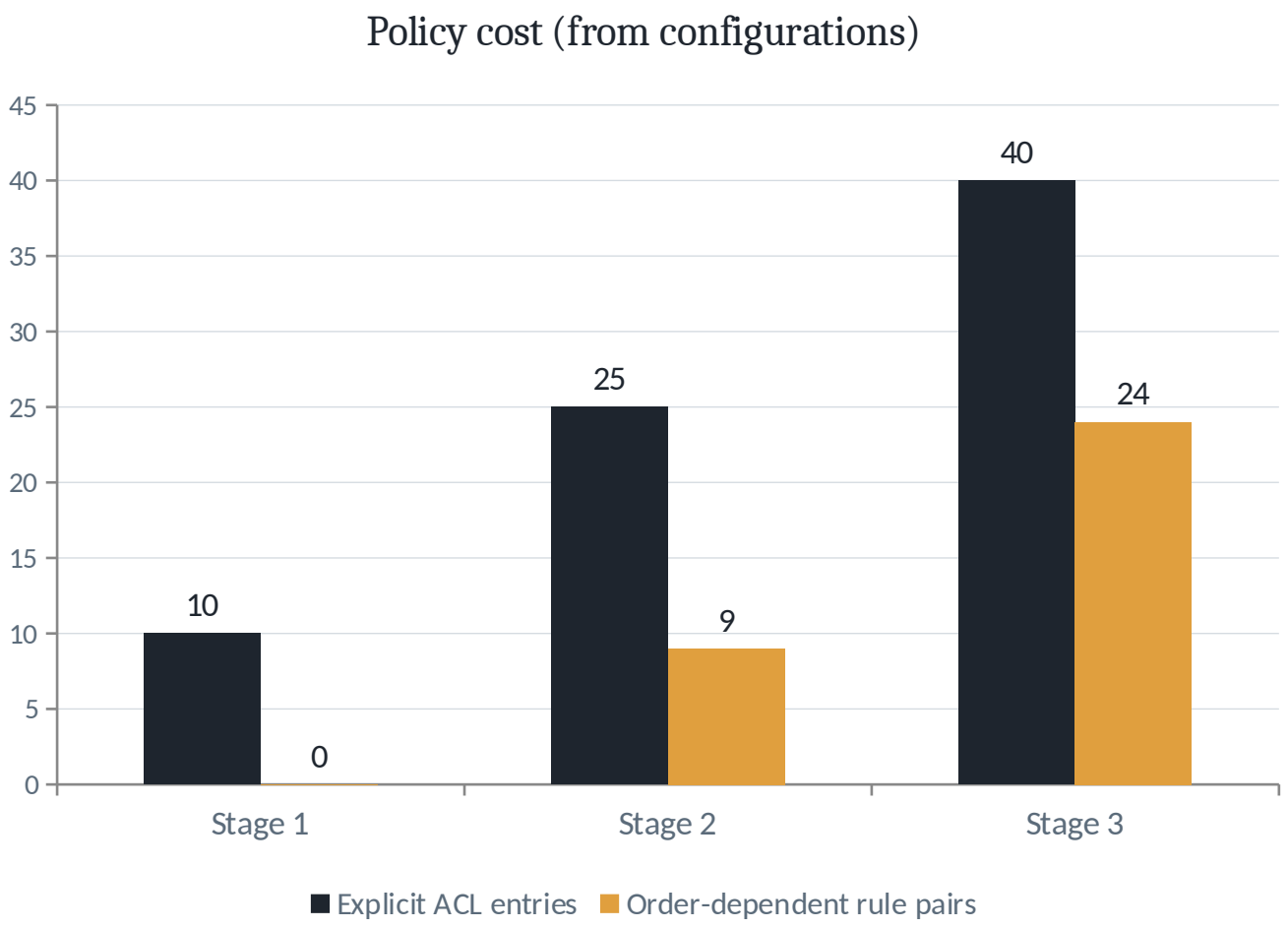
All observed results

Test	Flow	Type	S0	S1	S2	S3
T01	HR → web portal	Req	A	A	A	A
T03	HR → DNS	Req	A	n/e	A	n/e
T04	Finance → FTP	Req	P	n/e	n/e	P
T05	HR → HR records	Req	A	n/e	n/e	A
T06	IT → router SSH	Req	A	n/e	n/e	A
T14	IT → ping server	Req	A	n/e	A	n/e
T15	Internet → portal	Req	A	n/e	A	n/e
T17	HR → Internet web	Req	A	A	A	n/e
T07	HR → Finance PC	Forb	A	A	D	D

Test	Flow	Type	S0	S1	S2	S3
T08	Sales → FTP	Forb	A	n/e	A	D
T10	Sales → HR records	Forb	A	n/e	A	D
T11	Sales → router SSH	Forb	A	n/e	D	D
T12	Telnet → router	Forb	A	n/e	A	n/e
T13	HR → ping server	Forb	A	A	A	n/e
T16	Internet → FTP	Forb	A	n/e	D	n/e
T19	Sales → router SSH (2)	Forb	A	n/e	D	n/e
T18	Same-VLAN ping	Ctrl	A	n/e	A	n/e

Green = policy goal met · Red = forbidden flow worked or required flow failed · Amber P = partial (FTP login only) · n/e = no screenshot, excluded from counts · S0 has no rules, so every flow should work

Results: access fell as rules grew



Stage 1

2 of 2 forbidden flows worked

Stage 2

4 of 8 forbidden flows worked

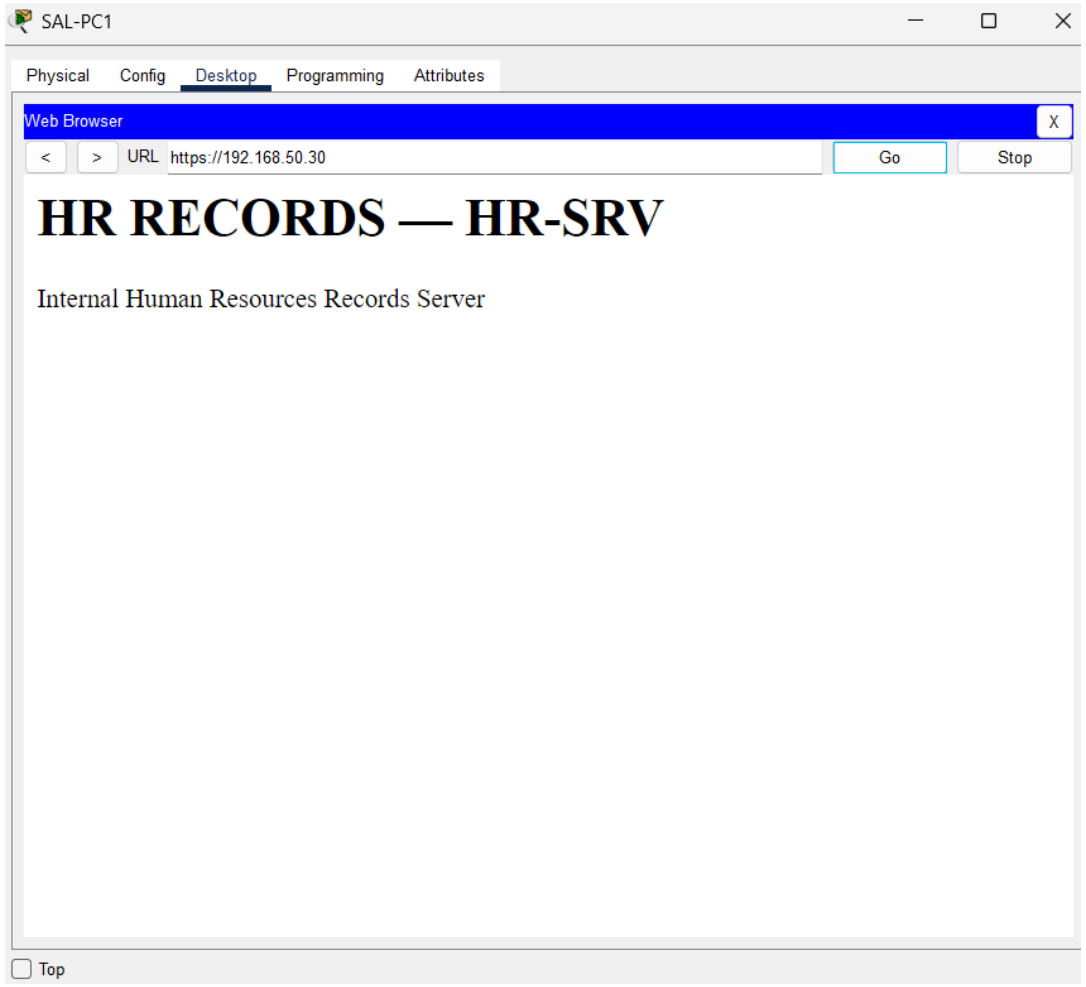
Stage 3

0 of 4 forbidden flows worked

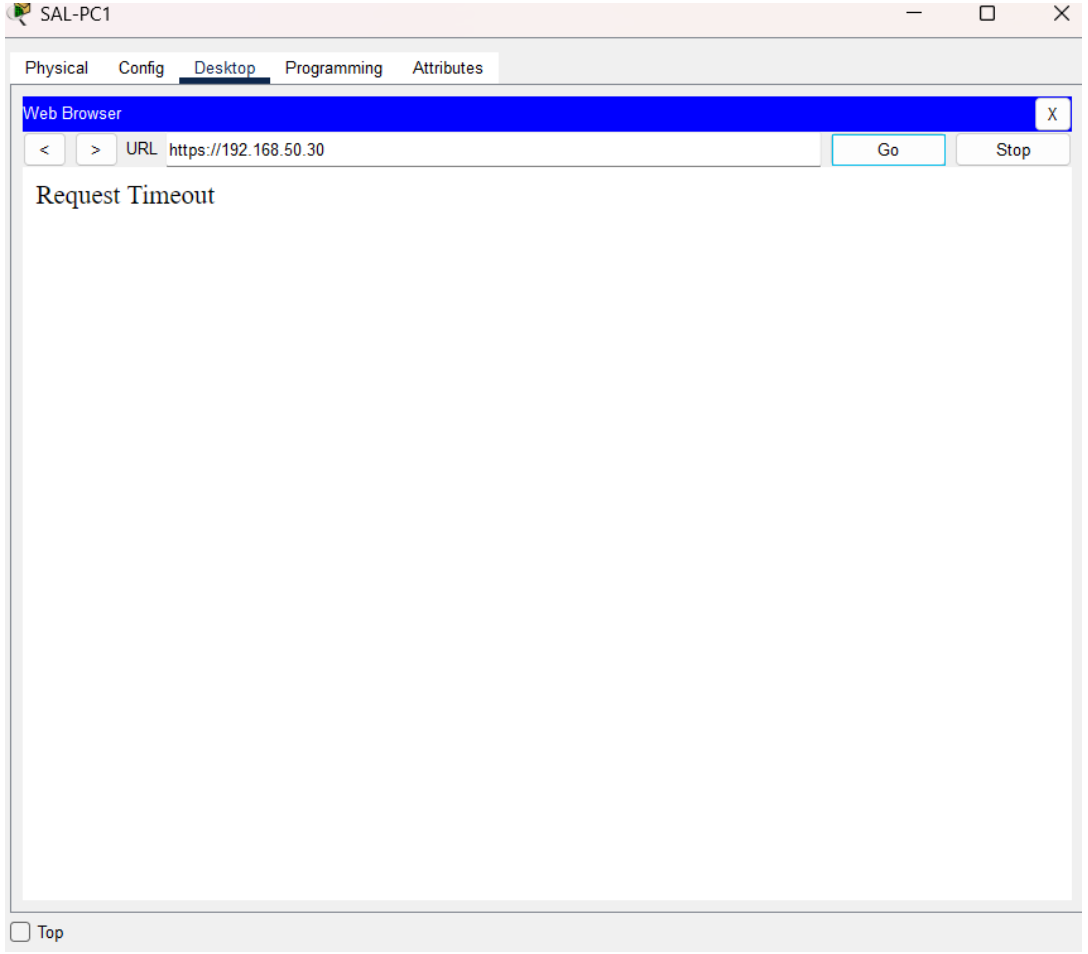
Counts cover only tests with screenshot evidence, so they are not compared as percentages.

Same test, two policies: Sales → HR records (T10)

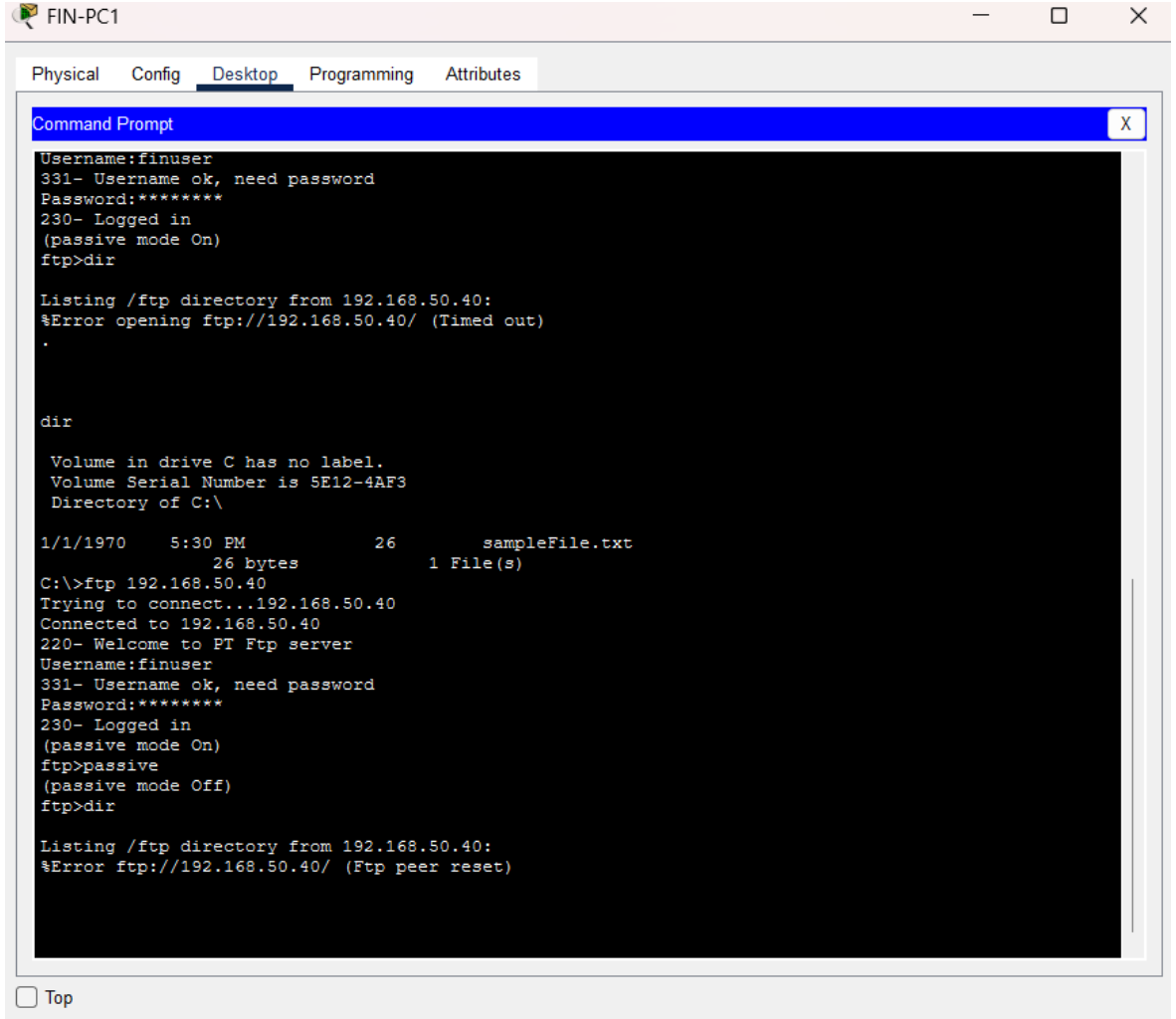
PERMIT Stage 2: department rule opens the whole server zone



DENY Stage 3: only HR may reach HR-SRV on port 443



Key finding: least privilege broke a required service



What happened

Finance could log in to its FTP server, but listing files failed: "Timed out" (passive) and "Ftp peer reset" (active).

Why

The Stage 3 rule permits only the FTP control port (21). FTP's separate data connection hits the "deny internal" rule.

So what

Least privilege costs more than rules: multi-connection services need extra, carefully ordered entries.

Other observations

Two locks, two symptoms

In Stage 2, Sales SSH to 192.168.40.1 timed out (interface ACL) while SSH to 192.168.50.1 was refused (router login rule): one goal, enforced in two places.

Rule count can mislead

The Stage 3 edge ACL is the strictest but has the fewest entries (6 → 6 → 5).

Same-VLAN traffic

HR-PC1 always reached HR-PC2: traffic inside a VLAN never passes the router, so no router ACL can filter it.

Build issues fixed

A duplicate IP on R-CORE and wrong server addresses were found in Stage 0 and corrected before testing.

How our results compare with the literature (Part C)

Observation	Literature	Relation
Forbidden flows: 2 of 2 → 4 of 8 → 0 of 4	[3], [5]	Agrees
Rules 10 → 25 → 40; order pairs 0 → 9 → 24	[2]	Agrees in direction
Strictest edge ACL has fewest entries	[9], [10]	Agrees: count misleads
Department rules still let Sales reach HR data	[4], [15]	Agrees: zone trust too coarse
Stage 3 broke FTP file listing	[13]	Partly: adds a concrete usability cost
Same-VLAN traffic never filtered	[15], [16]	Agrees: limit of router ACLs

We measured reachability and policy structure, not administrator error, so [2] is matched in direction, not proven.

Limitations

Small scale

19 devices and 40 rules, versus large real rule sets

Evidence gaps

Screenshots for 17 tests in Stage 0, 4 in Stage 1, 14 in Stage 2, 7 in Stage 3

Not Zero Trust

ACLs see addresses and ports, never user or device identity

Simulator models

FTP stands in for a database; no NAT, logging or attack traffic

Not run

Misconfiguration experiments M1 and M2; zero-hit and line-change metrics

Stateless filter

established accepts any TCP segment with ACK or RST set

Future work

Fix the FTP gap

Add one minimal, correctly ordered data-channel rule, or move the finance service to HTTPS/SFTP, and re-test

Run the mistake experiments

M1 (shadowed rule) and M2 (missing DNS rule) on copies of Stages 2 and 3

Complete the evidence

Capture every test and ACL counter in every stage; save running configs to measure lines changed

Stateful and identity-aware

Compare with a stateful firewall and with identity-based microsegmentation (Zero Trust)

Conclusion

Security improved

Forbidden access fell from broad to least privilege; all forbidden flows we captured were blocked in Stage 3

Cost rose

Rules grew 4× and order-dependent pairs from 0 to 24

Usability suffered

Least privilege broke FTP file listing until the policy is extended

Write the required flows first, then refine — the trade-off is real, and it can be measured.

Thank you · Questions?

Key references

[1] A. Wool, "A quantitative study of firewall configuration errors," Computer, 37(6), 2004.

[2] A. Wool, "Trends in firewall configuration errors," IEEE Internet Computing, 14(4), 2010.

[3] K. Scarfone, P. Hoffman, "Guidelines on firewalls and firewall policy," NIST SP 800-41r1, 2009.

[4] S. Rose et al., "Zero trust architecture," NIST SP 800-207, 2020.

[5] J. H. Saltzer, M. D. Schroeder, "The protection of information in computer systems," Proc. IEEE, 1975.

[9] E. Al-Shaer, H. Hamed, "Discovery of policy anomalies in distributed firewalls," INFOCOM, 2004.

[10] E. Al-Shaer et al., "Conflict classification and analysis of distributed firewall policies," IEEE JSAC, 2005.

[11] L. Yuan et al., "FIREMAN: A toolkit for firewall modeling and analysis," IEEE S&P, 2006.

[13] A. Voronkov et al., "Systematic literature review on usability of firewall configuration," ACM CSUR, 2017.

[15] R. Chandramouli, "Guide to a secure enterprise network landscape," NIST SP 800-215, 2022.

Full list of 18 references in the report (IEEE style).